

A SEAMLESS WORLD

In an engagingly written account of the human experience, Chanda examines globalisation both as the unfolding story of interaction and intermingling, and the bone of contention as we understand it now



BOUND TOGETHER: HOW TRADERS, PREACHERS, ADVENTURERS AND WARRIORS SHAPED GLOBALIZATION

by NAYAN CHANDA

Penguin

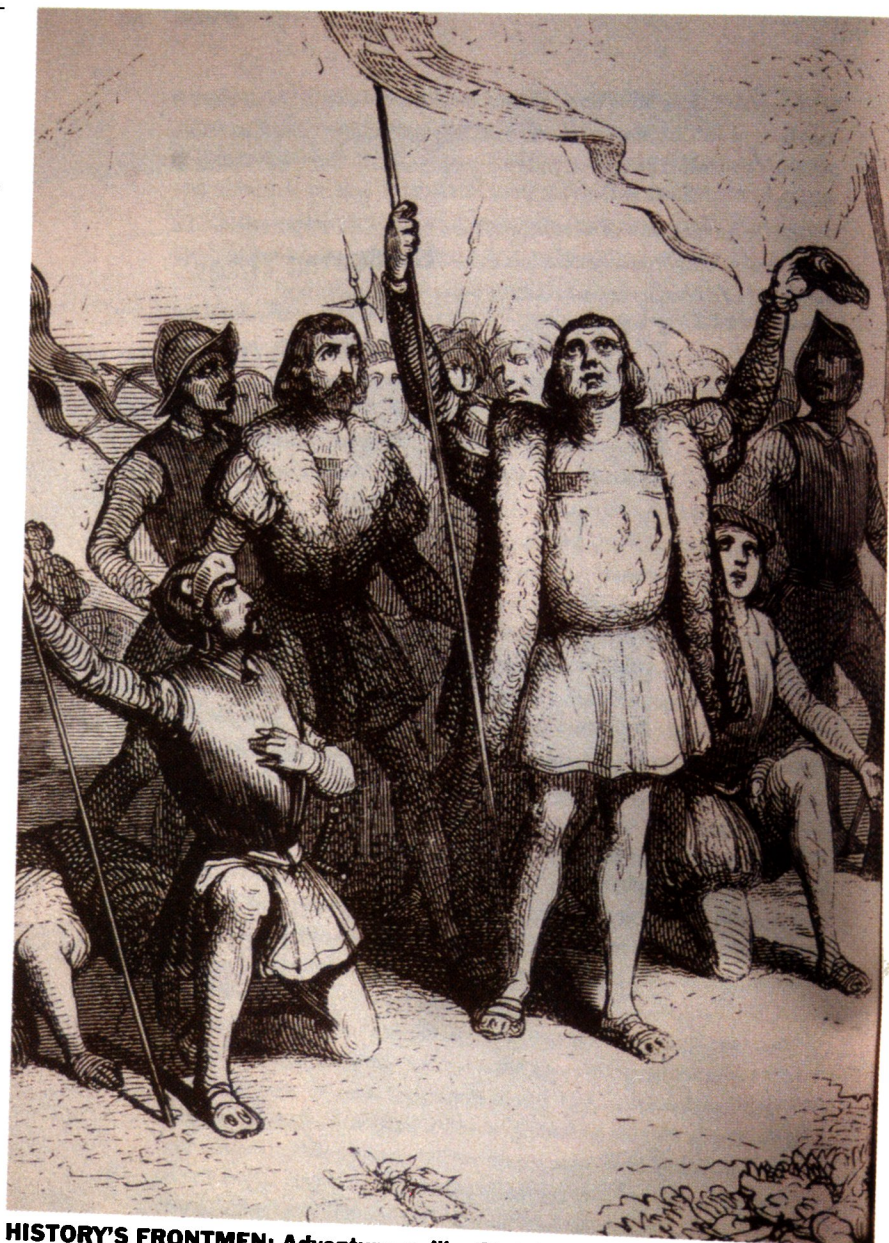
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■ By Pratap Bhanu Mehta

This is an exuberant history of the ways in which human beings have, from a common origin in Africa, first dispersed and then created inter-connections, in a process we now call globalisation. For Chanda, globalisation is not so much an ideology or an epoch as much as it is the unfolding story of human nature itself. Globalisation has been around as long as human beings have had to struggle to survive, had the desire for luxury, have been inventive, have reflected upon the meaning of their existence, have had the urge to adventure and the desire to dominate. So long as we produce traders, preachers, adventurers and yes, warriors, human cultures will interact and intermingle, their destinies dependent upon distant vagaries, and their problems and solutions contingent upon flows of human beings and what they produce.

This is not so much an analytical history of globalisation, as it is an engagingly written kaleidoscope of the human experience. It is teeming with human invention: from weaving to the Internet, with stories of sordid politics from slavery to empire, with accounts of missionary zeal from monks to human rights activists, with the obscenely rich and the appallingly poor, and every species of commodity from coffee to ivory, making and unmaking the world as we know it.

Pascal had ruefully remarked that half the world's problems lie in the fact that human beings cannot sit quietly in a room; he would have found this a wonderful catalogue of human restlessness and striving, with all its inventiveness and conflict. But the emphatic point is that we are bound



HISTORY'S FRONTMEN: Adventurers, like Christopher Columbus, who discovered the New World, were pioneers of what we now call globalisation

together in more ways than we can imagine: every commodity we consume bears some distant imprint, and almost every idea, including the thought that globalisation is bad, is a product of cultural interchange.

This is a book to savour for its telling detail, interesting stories, and strange ironies. But Chanda is also emphatic that this is a shared human story. The

very first chapter begins with an accessible account of the human dispersal from its origins in Africa, and the genetic markers that tell us the story of migration and intermingling. We are all cousins, in a manner of speaking. And perhaps the corollary is that we are often fratricidal for that reason.

The last three chapters are more analytical, examining globalisation as a